

has the best men, he has not only doubled the salaries of the existing rank and file in the army, but has also put aside money for equipping them with the latest weapons. Having the President for a brother helped, as there was no political resistance when he jacked up the defence budget to \$1.5 billion (Rs 6,000 crore) in 2007, a 100-per cent increase over the previous year's budget. Most importantly, he let Fonseka and the chiefs of the other two forces have a free hand.

Fonseka used the unfettered mandate to radically restructure his army. With photographs of lions adorning his chamber, the army commander speaks with a quiet confidence as he describes how he went about shaking up a moribund, ineffective and corrupt force into a fierce army that could take on the world's most feared terrorist organisation. He first appointed commanders who had proven themselves in military operations, brushing aside protocols of seniority. Fonseka, who pushed for extensive training of troops in jungle warfare and engineering, was given a *carte blanche* to buy weapons. He also started a major recruitment drive that saw close to 40,000 being inducted into the army in the past year, raising five new divisions. "We now have 25,000 new bayonets pointing at LTTE, not to mention the reserve units that can be brought into play if needed," he says.

Meanwhile, the Sri Lankan Air

The Government has antagonised the international community and has no new devolution plan for the Tamils.

RANIL WICKREMESINGHE
LEADER OF THE OPPOSITION



THE TIGER'S SURVIVAL PLAN



Prabhakaran (centre) with his cadre

- By withdrawing his army to the thick jungles of the Wanni, Prabhakaran is conserving his dwindling troops for a possible long battle.
- If he can hold off the Sri Lankan army for a year, the war would become political and economically unsustainable for the Government.
- Terror strikes wiping out important leaders would send the Government's calculations awry and cause panic among the common people.

"The Sinhala army continues to underestimate us and has fallen into our trap."

V. PRABHAKARAN
LTTE CHIEF, NOVEMBER 2007

Force and Navy, too, have begun to look smart. After the surprise bomb attacks on Colombo by two light aircraft that LTTE had smuggled in, the air force has imported radar—reportedly from India—to improve surveillance. A whole squadron of MIG 27 has been added. With better ground and air surveillance and bunker-buster bombs, the air force has made successful precision strikes. The navy, too, got its fair share of change, with better patrol boats and warships that have seen it destroy much of the Sea Tigers' fleet and floating arsenal in recent months. This has severely limited the flow of arms to LTTE from the sea, thereby diminishing their fighting capability. The Indian Navy has helped by quietly blockading the Jaffna seas and passing on critical information about movements of ships to the Sri Lankan Navy. US intelligence, too, has played a role in increasing the rate of successful interdiction of ships carrying weapons.

For the embattled LTTE, the options are dwindling. With the US and Europe designating it as a terrorist organisation,

much of its illegal funding has been blocked. The territories it had held in the east in the past had helped it get a constant supply of fresh recruits. With Karuna, a former LTTE eastern command chief, turning against Prabhakaran, the organisation is considerably weakened. Reportedly, the Tigers are now forced to conscript very young or middle-aged people not suited for fighting. It hasn't helped that its top leaders are either in their forties or fifties, making it a middle-aged army—a far cry from the young, battle-hardened guerrilla force that could once strike back with great ferocity and win big battles against the Sri Lankan Army. Prabhakaran himself is around 53 years old, has become portly, and is said to be suffering from ailments that possibly include diabetes. An accidental bomb blast left Soosai, the Sea Tiger chief, confined to his wheelchair and also killed his son. Balraj, deputy chief of the military, is also said to be ailing.

As the Sri Lankan Army's bombings get more accurate, Fonseka takes delight in the fact that he is giving